

of an essay originally published in 1948). But even in this period, the essay on "Tasso in England" provides, in a case history, remarkably fresh and vivid evidence of English attitudes toward Italy and Italian literature through the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, and even down to the Third Programme of the B.B.C. in 1952.

The final impression of the volume, then, is that of a literary history, or more specifically, of a history of an important literary relationship, in a special and relatively new sense of the term. It is a sense suggested by Praz himself in an Italian essay on "Literary History" published in the delightful and stimulating collection entitled *La casa della fama* (1952). Here, after a review of the isolated study and the sweeping survey as methods of the literary historian, he concludes that, for himself, the basis for any approach must be specific works themselves, specifically analyzed for their literary values. The essays brought together in *The Flaming Heart*, taken separately or as a whole, admirably exemplify this concept of literary history.

[JAMES E. PHILLIPS]

A HOUSE IN THE COUNTRY

Topicality of themes, and also mere accident, seem generally to rule the choice of works for translation from Italian into English. By and large, the situation could be much worse; but the field is still wide open for new discoveries. For example, as far as I know, the work of Giovanni Comisso has appeared so far in English translation only in the Slonim and the Strachan anthologies of modern Italian short stories; and it is represented there, perhaps misleadingly though I am sure unintentionally, by the same story in two different translations.

Yet Comisso's is one of the few absolutely genuine and consistent writing talents in contemporary Italy, where his name has been quite prominent for at least thirty years. He has received also, whatever that may indicate, two of the major literary prizes, at two moments wide apart in his career: the Bagutta Prize for his book "People of the Sea" (*Gente di mare*, 1929) and the Strega Prize for "A Cat Crosses the Street," a collection of stories (*Un gatto attraversa la strada*, 1955). Now over sixty, he belongs to the generation that fought in the First War, the memory of which, to people of his part of the country (he is from Treviso, a province of Venetia), has a singularly deep, familiar resonance. He then followed the poet D'Annunzio in his 1919 expedition for the conquest of the city of Fiume, an experience partly recorded in one of his early works, "In the Wind of the Adriatic" (*Al vento dello Adriatico*, 1928). Even after that, he has managed to impress upon his life the stamp of adventurousness and of free, exotic experience. To do this he has been helped by that mixed blessing of Italian

writers' lives which is the opportunity to practice literary or "third page" journalism. Comisso's poetic itineraries through China and Japan, for instance, in the early thirties, produced among other things his book *Amori d'Oriente*, which is hardly mere reportage, but has in fact permanent literary value. Itinerant journalism, to Comisso as to many others, has meant also a closely human and aesthetic possession of the foreign and remote, which is the best antidote to conventional aestheticism in literature. One of the present reviewer's recollections of Comisso in his country house near Treviso is the writer's affectionate insistence in defining the Japanese quality of the hills near him. There is a tendency to imagine that a writer like Comisso, who is often described as a "sensualist" or something of that sort, lacks substance because of the very immediacy and gusto of his perception; the superficial critic perhaps would again insist on calling his style loose, fit to follow the whims of an intense desire to experience. But especially now that Comisso has reached brilliant maturity, such a description fits less than ever; it would be as basically meaningless to say that the impressionist painters lack substance and face life with superficial hedonism. Of course a writer like Comisso does not, by nature, succeed in the long plotted narrative (though he has attempted something of the sort in a novel whose very title, *Storia di un patrimonio*, is a program) as in the short "atmosphere" story, or also in the poetic autobiography. Even in this last genre, however, there is no writer we would feel less prone to accuse of self-pleased aestheticism or of loose, unresolved quickness of perception. Actually, I believe Comisso is above all characterized by what I would simply call professionalism; and, since his narrative autobiographical voice is that of the hero-as-artist, professionalism here means coming importantly and competently to terms with experience through his proper medium, words; it means moral seriousness.

Comisso's latest book is of the autobiographical kind; actually it may turn out to be part of a series of books of recollection, each centering on a theme. The theme here is the country house of the title (*La mia casa di campagna*, Milan: Longanesi, 1958), from the time when the author bought it in the thirties to the time when he abandoned and sold it after the War. Also as a farmer he tried to be a professional: "In undertaking this life one should have no dilettantism, but one must live it seriously, and I was always ready to jump up at any hour of the day or night and in any weather, when the land and the chores claimed it" (p. 134). Landscape and human relationship are often treated with the detachment and precision of fictional art. However, though especially in the first part (p. 30 ff., for instance) one notices a tendency to compose "scenes" of country life, there is never any preciousness about it; in fact, what I mean by detachment is nothing but the competence of the literary artist, who participates also, indeed primarily, as artist in the life of which is a member. Comisso manages to make us

feel that the competence with which he attends to his farming business has the same root as his professionalism as a literary artist. Peasants are enormously difficult to describe. It is part of Comisso's triumph that he never turns out to be either "pastoral" or "neo-realistic" and "class-conscious." Some of his country experiences are comic, some are tragic; there is no trace of either condescension in the first instance, or of sentimentalism in the second. There are passages which practically amount to short stories in themselves; there are sharply vivid moments of time and landscape; there are even aphorisms. But there is never a sense of the self-conscious set piece, or of the intentionally "symbolic" exploitation of a situation or image. Yet through these pages, even the sense of Italian history in those years becomes intensely present. To give one example, I find toward the end (p. 240 ff.) passages which constitute, through apparently casual images of young boys and girls in a stable at night, one of the most poignant views of "post-war generations" that I have encountered; and this is done, as it were, inadvertently, without mentioning the fact.

It is difficult for the present reviewer to talk objectively about this book; himself a Venice-Venetian, he formed for ever his notion of "the countryside" on landscapes and images such as Comisso here abundantly offers; the name of the place, Zero Branco, is familiar to him since dimmest childhood; his maternal grandfather is the painter, mentioned in the first page, from whose heirs Comisso bought the place. Yet perhaps such circumstances make an attempt at critical definition more attractively challenging. One single point may be mentioned: the problem of language. Recent Italian fiction, in many cases, has posed again, as in the time of Verga, the problem of the relationship between written and spoken language, and the various questions which we may summarily refer to as regionalism. It is immensely revealing to realize that this book, though in many ways unmistakably local, never for a moment adopts even the least trace of vernacular flavor for its artistic effects. The much too celebrated discussions on local and national language appear trifling and academic by contrast. So also do the mannerisms of rustic *verismo*, with which a good deal of recent literature and cinema have afflicted us. But then Comisso aims at permanence; he allows himself to write such words as the following (p. 90): "I did not know what my future was. I felt I was fighting every day against solitude, with the water up to my throat. I sensed that my life was crashing about me, I knew that everything man could do was destined for decay, for dispersal, except art. One day everything might perish, even mankind, but a work of art might still have been able to survive on the parched and deserted earth. Alive for no one, but it would still exist." And he can write this without blushing, and without making us feel that he necessarily should.

[P.M.P.]

Under the enterprising direction of Agostino Lombardo three volumes of *Studi americani* (I, 1955; II, 1956; III, 1957; Edizioni di Storia e Letteratura, Rome) have already appeared. From a double perspective they can be considered significant: they represent the consolidation of serious Italian interest in American literature and they infuse fresh interest into questions that may wrongly seem trite by familiarity. Intensive Italian interest in American literature is relatively recent, though not far behind serious and comprehending American interest in American literature, and understandably it has in the past been sporadic and often injudicious. It was not, for instance, until 1932 that *Moby Dick* was translated by Cesare Pavese; and yet the genius of the book had barely begun to be appreciated in America. During fascism the image of America and American literature that took shape was compounded of a sense of discovery and perhaps an attitude of wishful thinking, not always balanced and informed. After the last war the prestige of Hemingway and Faulkner in particular, and the discovery of a richness and awareness in American literature in general (not to mention the political example of a strong democracy and the succession of superficial fashions imitated abroad), attracted foreign interest, especially among Italians, an interest which continues, now sustained more by recent American poetry and theater than by fiction. It is fitting, then, after thirty years of intermittently intensive discovery and exploration, that a calm, informed, properly critical view be taken in Italy of American literature, and, one might add, of Italy's significant experience of it. Also, it is fitting that Americans turn for refreshment to a foreign perspective on their own traditions: they may be taught to see familiar objects with new eyes and to discern the range of their ignorance.

Though unpredictably varied in subject and intensity, the many essays in these volumes show a kind of consistency. Most of them are composed as "essays" and not as "articles," if so invidious a distinction may be allowed. In other words, they usually achieve an easy relationship with the reader and they mostly succeed in avoiding stiffness and jargon (the phrase *sul piano di*, however, begins to show the luxuriance of *in terms of*). Besides, they are well informed and well documented to a point happily this side of pedantry. Most of the writers are young, versed in English and European literature, and nothing if not thorough readers of American authors. Surely no other country has produced so excellent and dedicated a circle of "intellectuals" concerned on a high level with America; not England or France, certainly. The view of American literature, as it is reflected in these essays, is governed by a conviction that a whole and separate national tradition actually exists.

Despite its hybrid shapelessness, American literature is almost the only literature foreigners still try to define as a thing in itself,